

English 2301: British Literature (Section 14)

Changing Natures • Tree Stories

Carroll Science 202

MWF, 12:20-1:10 p.m.

Fall 2025

This class counts for the A&S Core Curriculum (it fulfills the “Literature in Context” requirement).

It can also count for the English Major/Minor and the [Environmental Humanities Minor](#).

Instructor: Prof. Joshua King Joshua_King@baylor.edu (not online weekends or after 5 pm weekdays) Office: Carroll Science 317	Office Hours • Office, Carroll Science 317: MW 3:00-4:30 • Virtual (by Zoom): TR 1:00-2:30 • By appointment
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Our Journey: We will journey through imaginative achievements by authors connected to the British Isles. Often, we will reflect on the theme of “Changing Natures”—how this literature offers us shifting views of human nature and our relationships with the natural world, itself increasingly changed by humans.

Our path will take many turns, but it will often run through an ancient, far-flung literary forest whose trees have described and imagined by writers for over a thousand years. Like physical forests, this one has overstories and understories full of life, mystery, death, and growth. Poets, novelists, and essayists will be our guides. They’ll introduce us to leafy limbed beings who participate in Christ’s saving work; swell with fruit of the Fall; grow with and outlast their planters; shelter many creatures and unknown dangers; root memories, identities, and family trees; praise their Creator; build empires; vanish with destroyed environments and nuclear blasts; and sustain our every breath.

I am convinced that we best engage literature, and best understand its value, when we actively question and discuss what we read and relate it to our world and experiences—including the places we study. To that end, alongside class discussions and activities meant to help you develop your own views of readings, we will draw inspiration from writings about trees on our syllabus to shape our own reflections on the forest where we study—the more than 3,000 trees in “Baylor’s Urban Forest” ([shown on this map](#)). [Programs on campus are collaborating to tend and learn about these trees.](#) Arborists and biologists can monitor the physical health of our campus forest, but to encourage care and respect for these trees, we need stories binding them to our daily experiences and education.



You’ll contribute to this care by composing the first **Baylor Tree Stories**. Over the semester, you’ll be encouraged to find one tree on the campus map and visit it. You’ll write reflections about your tree in dialogue with your experiences and reading for class. At the end, you’ll build on these reflections to compose a Tree Story that **roots** us in observations about your tree, **branches** into connections with your experiences and class readings, and **leafs out** into a creative response to the tree that draws inspiration from our reading. **“Creative” does not mean you need to be an artist:** you have many options for your response—a thoughtful journal, a short reflective essay, a series of photos with narrative, a painting or piece of music, and more. Your Tree Stories will be turned into webpages and linked to your tree on the digital campus tree map.

Required Texts

1. William Shakespeare, *King Lear*, ed. R.A. Foakes (Arden, 3rd ed. 1997). ISBN: 9781903436592
2. Charles Dickens, *Hard Times*, ed. Kate Flint (Penguin Classics 1998). ISBN: 978-0141439679
3. JRR Tolkien, *The Hobbit* (Houghton Mifflin Harcourt 2012). ISBN: 978-0547928227

4. You must purchase the books listed above. Other readings will be in digital files in Modules. Enter the ISBN's above into Google or Amazon to find the right editions.

Texts, Readings, and Digital Devices in Class

- **Talk to me if you have trouble getting a copy of the books.** They are probably cheaper online: google the ISBN numbers above to ensure that you purchase the correct editions.
- **You are encouraged to use laptops/devices in class to . . .**
 - Access our digital readings (in Modules on Canvas) and save on printing.
 - Access handouts & other materials posted to Modules and participate in class activities.
 - Take our quizzes, midterm, and final exam.
- **You are NOT permitted to use laptops/devices to . . .**
 - Surf the internet, check/send messages, or work on assignments (for this class or other classes).
 - **People doing the above will first be given a warning and *will thereafter lose 5 participation points each time the behavior is repeated.***

Policies—Visit the "START HERE" section of Canvas for info. about. . .

- Who I am and how office hours will work
- policies for attendance, technology, and late assignments
- resources related to academic and personal flourishing

Next Page: Assignments Overview

Assignments Overview:

- Detailed guidelines and descriptions will be in “Assignments” on Canvas.

Assignment	Due Date/Explanation (All Guidelines on Canvas)	Points												
10 Quizzes	Unless noted otherwise , each quiz covers the reading up to and including the day it is due and will be available on Canvas by 2 p.m. the day before class and should be taken by the start of class .	200 (20%)												
Participation	This class invites you to contribute to our collective discovery. I will regularly invite you into discussions and group activities about the works we read, and I will expect you to be prepared. You begin the semester with a perfect participation score (100% of points), which you'll keep if you... Read, Prepare, Respond: I will often post handouts or discussion boards to Canvas with questions to consider before or during class and sometimes ask you to write short responses. Missing responses will result in losing <i>10 points</i>. Clear evidence of not preparing for class or not participating in class (e.g., surfing the web) will result in a warning. Thereafter, you will lose <i>5 points each time</i>. Respectfully Attend: Your presence impacts how much this class benefits you and your classmates. As explained in “Policies” under “Start Here” in Canvas, after two unexcused absences, each additional unexcused absence lowers your participation grade <i>by 20 points</i>.	200 (20%)												
Tree Stories	<i>Growing Your Story: Three Reflections</i> On Oct. 1, you'll be introduced to the Tree Stories project. You'll then select a tree on the digital campus map and write 3 reflections over the semester that will prepare you for your final Tree Story. The first will take root in observations about features of your tree (due 5 pm Oct. 15), the second will branch into connections with your experiences and class readings (due 5pm Nov. 12), and the third will leaf out into a consideration of your most striking observation and a proposal for your Tree Story (due by class on Dec. 3).	120 (40 each) (12%)												
	<i>Completed Tree Story (due Dec. 8 Start of Class):</i> You will build on your reflections to write a Tree Story. It will take root in your observations about the tree, branch into connections between your tree and your experiences and reading in class, and leaf out into a creative response to the tree that takes inspiration from our reading. <u>“Creative” does not mean you need to be artists or creative writers</u>; you have many options for your response—a thoughtful journal, a short reflective essay, a series of photos with narrative, a poem, a painting or piece of music, and more. Your Tree Stories will be converted into webpages and then linked to your tree on the campus digital tree map.	180 (18%)												
Midterm	<i>Open book & online between 12:20 p.m. Sept. 29 and 5 p.m. Sept. 30</i> Short-answer questions covering concepts and details from class discussion and 1 essay asking you to compare texts analytically. You will receive a study sheet.	150 (15%)												
Final Exam	<i>Open book & online Dec. 16 between 10:00 a.m. and 6:00 p.m.:</i> Short-answer questions and 1 essay, primarily on material after the midterm. We will have a "Final Review Game" to prepare you and you will receive a study sheet.	150 (15%)												
Extra Credit	There are opportunities for earning extra credit (20 points of extra credit for each opportunity, up to 40 total). See Extra Credit in Assignments on Canvas.	40 max												
Total Points		1,000												
Grade Ranges	<table><tr><td>870-899: B+</td><td>770-799: C+</td><td>670-699: D+</td><td>0-599: F</td></tr><tr><td>940-1000: A</td><td>840-869: B</td><td>740-769: C</td><td>640-669: D</td></tr><tr><td>900-939: A-</td><td>800-839: B-</td><td>700-739: C-</td><td>600-639: D-</td></tr></table>	870-899: B+	770-799: C+	670-699: D+	0-599: F	940-1000: A	840-869: B	740-769: C	640-669: D	900-939: A-	800-839: B-	700-739: C-	600-639: D-	
870-899: B+	770-799: C+	670-699: D+	0-599: F											
940-1000: A	840-869: B	740-769: C	640-669: D											
900-939: A-	800-839: B-	700-739: C-	600-639: D-											

Reading Calendar

- **Listed next to each day are the readings you need to finish by that date.** Read all assigned pieces and come to class prepared to discuss prompts on handouts that will be posted to Canvas in advance.
- **Readings with “Digital”** next to them are in “Digital Readings” can be found on Canvas under the corresponding date in Modules.
- **Helpful Notes/Due Dates** are listed in columns next to readings.
- **Note—your Participation grade** is impacted by completing responses that will sometimes be due by the time of class. These are not noted on the syllabus, but they will always be announced by the prior class meeting.

Date	Reading Assignment	Notes/Due Dates
Week 1		
Mon. Aug. 25	Introductions; Changing Natures: Our Journey through British Literature [Digital] Christina Rossetti, “A Dumb Friend” (1863) Hone Tuwhare, “No Ordinary Sun” (1964)	Be sure to bring devices to class that you can use to access the digital readings during class discussion. This applies to all days on which we discuss digital-based readings. All digital readings are marked “[Digital]” in the syllabus and can be accessed on Canvas under the corresponding date in Modules.
Unit 1. Varied Roots (Medieval Literature): <i>Early Views of Creator, Creation, and Creatures</i>		
Wed. Aug. 27	[All readings today Digital] “Bede and Caedmon’s Hymn” (selection from Bede’s <i>An Ecclesiastical History of the English People</i>); “The Dream of the Rood”; “Early Irish Lyrics [by Irish monastic scribes]”	Before class, please also review the pages in the “Start Here” Module on Canvas. Pay attention to the “Policies” and “Syllabus” pages. The latter is linked to a page with the full syllabus, which you can download to have at hand. Please ask any questions that come to mind about class policies and assignments.

Fri. Aug. 29	[All readings today Digital] Julian of Norwich • Introduction to Julian of Norwich's life (Wikipedia) • From <i>A Book of Showings to the anchoress Julian of Norwich</i> (written c. 1390s, also known as <i>Revelations of Divine Love</i>; earliest known work in English by a woman): ○ Taste of the Middle English in which Julian originally wrote: Chapter V [5] from <i>The Shewings of Julian of Norwich</i>, ed. Georgia Ronan Crampton. ○ Selections: Chapters 5, 58-61, and 86 from modern translation and arrangement, <i>All Shall Be Well: Daily Readings from Julian of Norwich, Revelations of Divine Love</i> by Sheila Upjohn (1992).	
Week 2		
Mon. Sept. 1	Labor Day: University Holiday	
Wed. Sept. 3	[Digital] <i>The Canterbury Tales</i> "The Prologue"	
Fri. Sept. 5	[Digital] <i>The Canterbury Tales</i> "The Wife of Bath's Prologue and Tale"	Reading Quiz 1 Due: Unless otherwise noted, quizzes will be available on Canvas by 2 p.m. the day before class and should be taken by the start of class.
Week 3		
Mon. Sept. 8	[Digital] <i>The Canterbury Tales</i> "The Pardoner's Prologue and Tale"	
Wed. Sept. 10	[Digital] Geoffrey Chaucer <i>The Canterbury Tales</i> : "The Nun's Priest's Tale," pp. 214-231; "The Parson's Prologue," pp. 485-497, and "Chaucer's Retraction," p. 489.	
Unit 2. Troubled Growth (Early Modern Literature): <i>The Cosmos Disordered and Reordered</i>		
Fri. Sept. 12	William Shakespeare: [Digital] William Shakespeare Introductory Materials <i>King Lear</i> (book, Arden edition): Acts 1-2, pp. 157-258	Reading Quiz 2 Due (focused on Chaucer from previous unit and Act 1 of <i>King Lear</i> for this unit) This is one of the required hard copy books for our class. Here is the ISBN you can put into Google or Amazon to obtain the correct edition: 9781903436592

Week 4		
Mon. Sept. 15	<u><i>King Lear</i> (Arden): Act 3</u>	
Wed. Sept. 17	<u><i>King Lear</i> (Arden): Act 4</u>	
Fri. Sept. 19	<u><i>King Lear</i> (Arden): Act 5, pp. 357-392</u>	Reading Quiz 3 (We'll take this together in class. Everyone present will gain credit if you can cooperate to answer the questions successfully.)
Week 5		
Mon. Sept. 22	John Milton: [Digital] John Milton Introductory Materials [Digital] <i>Paradise Lost: Selections from Books I and II.</i>	Note: The selections include the "Arguments" for each book. This is an old-fashioned word for "summary." It will help to read these first before reading the selections, just so you have a sense of what happens in each book.
Wed. Sept. 24	[Digital] <i>Paradise Lost: Selections from Books II, III, & IV</i>	
Fri. Sept. 26	[Digital] <i>Paradise Lost: Selections from Books IX: 1-415, 532-end & X.1-228</i> (as before, remember to read the "Arguments" that summarize the contents)	Reading Quiz 4 (We'll take this together in class. Everyone present will gain credit if you can cooperate to answer the questions successfully.)
Week 6		
Mon. Sept. 29 - Tues. Sept. 30	<u>Midterm Due 5 p.m. on Tuesday, Sept. 30</u> The exam will open Monday, Sept. 29 at the start of our regular class session (12:20 p.m.) and will close 5:00 p.m. on Tuesday, Sept. 30. You will have 50 minutes to complete the exam once it is opened.	

Unit 3. Wild Branching (Romantic & Victorian Literature): *Dislocations and Dreams of Progress in a Human-Altered World*

Wed. Oct. 1	Tree Stories Project Workshop 1 This workshop will prepare you for the Tree Stories Project. Over the semester, you'll write reflections on a tree of your choice in Baylor's Urban Forest in dialogue with your experiences and reading for class. Click here to see the interactive map of 3,000 campus trees. At the end, you'll compose a Tree Story that will be linked to your tree on the digital map and that roots us in observations about this tree, branches into connections with your experiences and class readings, and leafs out into a creative response to the tree that draws inspiration from our reading. "Creative" does not mean you have to be an artist or creative writer: you have many options to craft a response informed by your own interests. Today, we'll ... • Introduce project goals, requirements, and resources • Briefly discuss related assigned preparatory reading (see below) • Hear about "urban forests" and what it means to treat our campus as one from a special guest, Hector Marines-Chio (Regional Urban Forester from Texas A&M Forest Service) • Use the digital map of Baylor's Urban Forest during a walk outside to begin identifying, observing, and asking questions about trees that you might wish to make the subject of your Tree Stories • Preparation: Review the Tree Stories project introduction on Canvas; read these two short pieces ○ [Digital] William Cooper, "The Poplar Field" (poem) ○ [Digital] Fiona Stafford, "Poplar" (reflective essay) from <i>The Long, Long Lives of Trees</i> (2016)	Note: We will begin in our regular classroom and then walk outside for workshop activities. Try to arrive a bit early so we can be sure to start on time and demonstrate respect to our special guest, Hector Marines-Chio, the Regional Urban Forester for Texas A&M Forest Service.
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Fri. Oct. 3	William Blake: [Digital]: William Blake Introductory Materials [Digital]: from <i>Songs of Innocence</i>: “The Lamb,” “The Chimney Sweeper”; <i>Songs of Experience</i>: “The Chimney Sweeper,” “The Tyger”	
Week 7		
Mon. Oct. 6	William Wordsworth: [Digital] William Wordsworth Introductory Materials; "Lines Written in Early Spring"; [Digital] portions of <i>The Prelude</i>, Book VII (1805 version): lines 81-280, 589-741; VIII (1805 version): lines 797-859	
Wed. Oct. 8	William and Dorothy Wordsworth: William: [Digital] "I wandered lonely as a cloud" Dorothy: [Digital] introduction to "Dorothy Wordsworth" and this entry from the <i>Grasmere Journals</i>: Tuesday, [Apr.] 15th, 1802	Reading Quiz 5 (due by time of class)
Fri. Oct. 10	Fall Break, No Class	
Week 8		
Mon. Oct. 13	[All Readings Are Digital] Wordsworths on Trees and other Neighbors: William: “Nutting,” “Yew-Trees,” “When, to the attractions of the busy world” Dorothy: meditations on daily life and neighbors—humans, trees, birds, flowers, and others— in <i>Grasmere Journal</i>: May 14-19, 1800 (pp. 1-3), June 16, 1800 (p. 11), Nov. 24, 1801 (pp. 40-41), Feb. 12, 1802 (pp. 66-67), 6 May, 1802 (pp. 96-97), May 28-June 2, 1802 (pp. 102-104); June 16-19 (pp. 109-112).	

Wed. Oct. 15	John Clare: [Digital] "Introduction" to John Clare; "Remembrances"; "The Lament of Swordy Well"; Short poems on Bird Homes: "Birds Nests," "Sedge Birds Nest," "The Thrushes Nest," "The Pettichap's Nest" Note: Clare, a laboring-class rural poet, often uses regional words. You will find it helpful to consult the glossary linked on Canvas for some of them.	Due by 5pm Today: 1st Tree Reflection ("Rooting"), part of the Tree Stories project
Fri. Oct. 17	Elizabeth Barrett Browning: [Digital] Introduction to "Elizabeth Barrett Browning" [Digital] "The Cry of the Children" [Digital]: International exhibition on "Cry of the Children" by my previous students	Reading Quiz 6 (We'll take this together in class. Everyone present will gain credit if you can cooperate to answer the questions successfully.)
Week 9		
Mon. Oct. 20	Christina Rossetti: [Digital] "To What Purpose is This Waste" (1853) and from <i>Time Flies: A Reading Diary</i> (1885): July 5-7, July 17-19. Optional: Additional reading that you might find helpful, Joshua King, "Christina Rossetti," <i>The Palgrave Encyclopedia of Victorian Women's Writing</i> (2019) [Digital]	

Wed. Oct. 22	[All Readings Are Digital] Christina Rossetti: “A_Dumb Friend”; “All Thy Works Praise Thee, O Lord’: A Processional of Creation” Teresa Berger, “All Creation Worships: Re-thinking Liturgy in a Time of Ecological Emergency,” Centro Pro Unione Conference, 2021. • Article form of the lecture (read this version and use the other links to supplement if you like). • Lecture video • Lecture podcast (with Q&A) "Benedicte, omnia opera," <i>The Book of Common Prayer</i> Extra Credit Opportunities: You can watch and email me responses—each for 20 points—to the recording/article by Teresa Berger above, and/or of an academic lecture I gave on Christina Rossetti’s vision of creation’s worship. Optional: Those interested in learning more about Christina Rossetti’s vision of creation as a community of praise, and her view that the life of the world to come had to be approached through compassion for other creatures, might be interested in two more articles: Joshua King, “Revelatory Beasts: Christina Rossetti on the Apocalypse and Creation’s Worship,” <i>Christianity and Literature</i> 70.4 (2021); Joshua King, “I all-creation sing’: Christina Rossetti’s Cosmic Liturgy and Challenge to Anthropocentrism.” In <i>Ecoflourishing and Virtue: Christian Perspectives across the Disciplines</i> (2023).	
Fri. Oct. 24	Charles Dickens, <i>Hard Times</i> (book, edited by Kate Flint), First Book: Chapters 1-8	Reading Quiz 7 (due by the time of class) This is one of the required hard copy books for our class. Here is the ISBN you can put into Google or Amazon to obtain the correct edition: 978-0141439679
Week 10		
Mon. Oct. 27	Charles Dickens, <i>Hard Times</i>, First Book: Chapters 9-16	

Wed. Oct. 29	Charles Dickens, <i>Hard Times</i> , Second Book: Chapters 1-7	
Fri. Oct. 31	Charles Dickens, <i>Hard Times</i> , Second Book: Chapter 8 through Third Book: Chapter 3	Reading Quiz 8 (due by time of class)
Week 11		
Mon. Nov. 3	Charles Dickens, <i>Hard Times</i> , Third Book: Chapters 4-9.	
Wed. Nov. 5	Gerard Manley Hopkins: [Digital] "Gerard Manley Hopkins" (introduction to his life); "God's Grandeur"; "Inversnaid"; "Binsey Poplars"; "Ashboughs"	
Fri. Nov. 7	[All readings today Digital] Toru Dutt: "Toru Dutt" (introduction to her life); "Our Casurina Tree"; "Sonnet—Baugmaree"; "Sonnet—The Lotus" Rabindranath Tagore: "Balai"(1928)	Reading Quiz 9 (due by time of class)
Unit 4. Blight and Budding (Twentieth-Century & Contemporary Literature) <i>Uprooted and Reimagined Lives in a Vulnerable Earth</i>		
Week 12		
Mon. Nov. 10	J.R.R. Tolkien: <i>The Hobbit</i> (first published 1937), Chapter I ("An Unexpected Party") through Chapter V ("Riddles in the Dark")	This is one of the required hard copy books for our class. Here is the ISBN you can put into Google or Amazon to obtain the correct edition: 978-0547928227

Wed. Nov. 12	<i>The Hobbit</i> , Chapter VI (“Out of the Frying-Pain into the Fire”) through Chapter IX (“Barrels Out of Bond”)	Due by 5pm Today: 2nd Tree Reflection (“Branching”), part of Tree Stories project
Fri. Nov. 14	No class: Dr. King out of town presenting at conference	
Week 13		
Mon. Nov. 17	<i>The Hobbit</i> , Chapter X (“Warm Welcome”) through Chapter XIV (“Fire and Water”)	
Wed. Nov. 19	<i>The Hobbit</i> , Chapter XV (“The Gathering Clouds”) through Chapter XIX (“The Last Stage”)	
Fri. Nov. 21	[All Readings Are Digital] Hone Tuwhare, “No Ordinary Sun” (1964) Craig Santos Perez, “Family Trees” (2016), “We Aren’t the Only Species” (2020) Pascale Petit, “Rainforest in the Sleep Room” (2020) Click to hear Pascale Petit read the poem: https://poetryarchive.org/poem/rainforest-in-the-sleep-room/	Reading Quiz 10 (We’ll take this together in class. Everyone present will gain credit if you can cooperate to answer the questions successfully.)
Thanksgiving Break, Nov. 22 (Saturday)–Nov. 30 (Sunday)		
Week 14		
Mon. Dec. 1	[All Readings Are Digital] Robert MacFarlane, from <i>Underland</i> (2019) Zakiya McKenzie, “An Elegy for Lignum Vitae” (2021)	

Wed. Dec. 3	Tree Stories Project Workshop 2 - We will address any remaining questions you have about the Tree Stories due on Monday (Dec. 8). In groups, you will discuss your third Tree Reflections (“Leafing”), which are due by the start of class today, and in which you’ll include proposals for your final Tree Stories. You will help each other consider strategies for completing your projects, and I will circle between the groups addressing questions. - A few more poems on trees are included in the reading today for inspiration. We might have time to discuss them as well! A Cluster of Lake District Trees by Later Poets [All Digital] Elizabeth Delmore, “Yew” (1986) Helen Mort, “Grasmere Oak” (2013) Tom Rawling, “Alder Tree” (late 20th Century)	Due START OF CLASS: 3rd Tree Reflection (“Leafing”), part of the Tree Stories project
Fri. Dec. 5	Final Review Game	In class, we’ll hold a “game show” review to help you prepare for the final.
Week 15		
Mon. Dec. 8	Tree Stories: First Round of Presentations.	DUE: All Tree Stories must be submitted by the time of class today.
Wed. Dec. 10 Last Day of Class	Tree Stories: Second Round of Presentations.	
Week 16 Due 6:00 p.m. _____	<u>Final Exam Due 6:00 p.m. Dec. 16</u> You can take this exam between 10:00 a.m. and 6:00 p.m. You will have 2 hours to finish once you have begun.	Exam will be taken asynchronously online.